M365-21 · Tenant Configuration Change Control

How a change to the Microsoft 365 tenant is proposed, recorded and reversed — and why the directory attribute register matters more than it sounds.

Field	Value
Document ID	M365-21
Version	1.0 · Known Good edition, by Kevin Zelman
Catalogue domain	A. Microsoft 365
Operating tier	Tier 4 — IT Management approves; Tier 3 executes.
Review cycle	Annually.

1. Purpose

A tenant setting changed on a Tuesday can affect every member of the organization on Wednesday, and there is frequently no way to tell afterwards what was changed or why. This document is a light change process for tenant configuration — light enough to actually be used, which is the only kind that works in a small department.

2. What counts as a tenant change

- Conditional Access policies, authentication methods and authentication strengths.
- Sharing and guest settings, at tenant or site-collection level.
- Retention, labelling and data loss prevention policies.
- Directory schema: extension attributes, and what populates them (§3).
- Dynamic group rules over a whole population.
- Licensing assignment rules.
- Mail flow rules, connectors and the external-mail banner.
- Anything that changes what a user sees or can do without them asking for it. Not in scope: adding a person to a group, provisioning a site or mailbox, or any per-user action — those are governed by their own documents. The test is whether the change affects a population rather than a person.

3. The finite resources

> **Some tenant resources cannot be un-allocated once committed.**
>
> Directory extension attributes are the clearest example. There are fifteen, each can serve one purpose, and once a system depends on one it cannot be repurposed without breaking that system.
>
> A typical case: a department asks for a new dynamic group, and the attribute it needs has already been committed to the ticketing system. Declining is the correct answer and it is very hard to explain, because the commitment was made at some point by somebody for a good reason and nothing recorded it.
>
> So: no attribute is committed without a change record under this document, and IT maintains a register of what each one holds, what populates it, and what depends on it (M365-04 §7).

The same care applies to anything else the tenant has a limited number of, or that becomes load-bearing once something depends on it — mail domains, tenant-wide policy slots, and naming conventions once they are in use.

4. Proposing a change

1. Anybody in IT may propose. The proposal states: what changes, why, who it affects, what could go wrong, and how it is reversed.
2. That last field is the important one. A change nobody can describe reversing is a change nobody should make on a Friday.
3. Tier 3 assesses the blast radius: how many people, which populations, and whether anybody is affected who cannot easily tell IT that something broke — people on leave, part-time staff, guests.
4. Tier 4 approves. For anything affecting the whole organization, the Head of IT approves explicitly rather than by absence of objection.
5. Where the change can be piloted, it is piloted. Where it can run in report-only first, it does.
6. Schedule it under GOV-04. Not at the end of a Friday, and not during a business deadline or the first week of a busy season.
7. Make the change, verify it did what was intended, and record it per §6.

5. Changes that require extra care

Change	The specific risk	Required
Conditional Access	Locks people out at scale, immediately, with no warning to them and often none to IT.	Report-only for at least ten business days. Break-glass exclusion verified BEFORE enabling (ACC-07 §6). This is the change behind the classic MFA setup loop.
Authentication methods or strengths	Same as above, plus the registration-endpoint trap (ACC-03 §11.1).	Wave rollout per ACC-03 §11.2.
Directory attributes	Irreversible commitment (§3).	Register updated as part of the change, not afterwards.

Change	The specific risk	Required
Retention or deletion policies	Can destroy data. The failure is silent and discovered much later.	Tested on a scoped pilot. Never applied tenant-wide first. Confirm what it deletes, not what it retains.
Mail flow rules	Can silently drop or misroute mail. Nobody reports mail they never knew was sent to them.	Piloted, and monitored for 48 hours after.
Sharing settings	Tightening breaks existing links people depend on; loosening exposes content.	Report what will break before changing it.
Licensing rules	Removing a licence removes services, and can remove data with them.	Confirm data survives (ACC-01 §7.3).

6. Recording it

A change record is short. Appendix A is the whole thing, and it should take five minutes.

- What was changed, in terms somebody could use to find the setting again.
- Why, and who asked.
- Who approved, and who made the change.
- When — the actual time, because correlating a change with the tickets it caused is the main use of this record.
- What was observed afterwards.
- How to reverse it. The records live in one place and are searchable. Their value is almost entirely retrospective: when something behaves oddly three weeks later, the first question is what changed, and a department that can answer that in two minutes saves itself a day.

7. Reversing it

- Any Tier 3 engineer may reverse a change that is actively causing harm, immediately, without approval. Record it afterwards.
- That authority is stated deliberately. A change process that makes people hesitate to undo a breaking change is worse than no process.
- A reversal is itself recorded, with what was observed.
- A change reversed twice is not re-attempted without a different approach and a Tier 4 conversation.

8. Service levels

Activity	Commitment (per GOV-06)
Change proposal assessment	P3 — 3 coverage days at Tier 3.
Tier 4 approval	5 coverage days, or immediately where it accompanies an incident.

Activity	Commitment (per GOV-06)
Emergency change during an incident	Immediate. Recorded within 24 hours (GOV-03 takes precedence).
Reversal of a harmful change	Immediate, by any Tier 3 engineer, no approval needed.
Attribute commitment	Tier 4 decision. Not made at the desk, ever.

9. Records

Record	Held in	Retention
Change record (Appendix A)	IT change log	7 years
Attribute register	IT register	Permanent — this one matters most
Report-only evidence for Conditional Access changes	Project record	3 years
Reversals, with what was observed	IT change log	7 years
Emergency changes made during incidents	Change log + incident record	7 years

10. Related documents

ID	Title	Relationship
GOV-04	IT Change Management & Maintenance Windows	The wider change process. This document is its tenant-specific instance.
M365-04	Distribution List & Dynamic Group Standard	§7 attribute register lives there operationally.
M365-14	External Sharing & Guest Access Governance	Sharing settings changed here.
M365-16	Retention, Legal Hold & eDiscovery	Retention policy changes.
M365-20	License Assignment & Reclamation	Licensing rule changes.
ACC-03	MFA Enrollment, Reset & Account Recovery	Authentication changes, and §5.
ACC-07	Privileged & Administrative Account Standard	Break-glass exclusion verification.
DEV-02	Device Compliance & Configuration Baseline	Compliance policy enforcement is a tenant change.
GOV-03	Security Incident Response	Emergency changes.

Appendix A — Change record

Five minutes. Its value is retrospective: “what changed three weeks ago?” should take two minutes to answer.

Field	
Reference	
What changed	Specific enough to find the setting again.
Why, and who asked	
Who is affected	Which populations, and how many.
What could go wrong	Written before, not after.
How to reverse it	Required. If this cannot be answered, do not proceed.
Piloted or report-only first?	Required for anything in M365-21 §5.
Approved by	Tier 4. Named.
Made by, and when	Actual date and time.
Observed afterwards	What was checked, and what it showed.
Reversed?	If so, when, why, and what was observed.

Part of the Known Good SOP Catalog by Kevin Zelman, written for small IT shops, contractors and consultants, career-changers and help desk technicians. Adapt the names, tiers and times to your own shop: the times here are cushion, not a promise.